

SOURCE: <https://www.fluentu.com/blog/english/gerunds-and-infinitives/>

RULE 1: Gerunds can be used as a subject of a sentence.

Take a look at some examples:

Walking is good for your health.

Making friends has become more difficult since I moved to a new city.

Becoming a millionaire is a dream of many young people today.

Here, the gerunds (**in bold**) are part of the sentence subjects ("walking," "making friends," "becoming a millionaire"). All three sentences sound like normal, everyday English.

Now read these two sentences:

"To be or not to be—that is the question."

"To mourn a mischief that is past and gone is the next way to draw new mischief on."

(Both sentences are quotes from William Shakespeare's works.)

They sound formal, don't they? They are poetic, aren't they? Shakespeare is one of the greatest authors of all time, but his English is famously difficult to understand. And that's because it is literature. It is formal and it is art.

In those two quotes, the infinitives "to be" and "to mourn" are used as the sentence subjects.

So, it is possible to use both infinitives and gerunds as subjects, but gerunds are much more commonly used as subjects. Just pay attention to how the choice reflects on the tone and meaning of your sentences.

RULE 2: Both gerunds and infinitives can be used as objects of a sentence.

You may say:

"I enjoy **drawing**."

You may also say:

"Yesterday, I decided **to draw**."

Both sentences are correct, but one has an infinitive as the object and the other has a gerund as the object.

What is the difference?

It's the verbs that precede (come before) the object! Some verbs require a gerund and some will require an infinitive. In the above examples, we can see that the formula is **"enjoy" + [gerund]** and **"decide" + [infinitive]**.

With practice, you will be able to remember which one is which.

Here are a few examples of **verbs that need to be followed by an infinitive**:

agree: I agreed to go to a party with my friend.

decide: The president decided not to participate in the discussions.

deserve: Everyone deserves to be respected.

expect: I expect to know my exam grade by tomorrow.

hope: We were hoping to avoid traffic by leaving early.

learn: He learned not to trust anyone.

need: She needs to learn how to cook.

offer: I offered to help my brother with homework.

plan: We are planning to watch a movie tonight.

promise: My friend promised to find the time to help me move.

seem: We seem to be lost.

wait: I cannot wait to see my family.

want: I don't want to go to bed yet.

There are lots of verbs that require an infinitive after. You will learn them naturally, as you progress in your English studies.

admit: *They admitted changing the schedule.*

advise: *I advise proceeding (moving forward) with caution.*

avoid: *She avoided looking me in the eye.*

consider (think about): *I considered staying silent, but I had to tell her.*

deny: *I denied knowing about his secret.*

involve: *The course involved writing three tests.*

mention (say something): *She mentioned seeing my brother at a baseball game.*

recommend: *I recommend practicing gerunds and infinitives.*

risk: *Don't risk losing your job!*

suggest: *I suggest reading more English short stories.*

RULE 3: Infinitives should be used after many adjectives.

Here are three sample sentences that will help to illustrate this rule:

*It is not easy **to graduate** from university.*

*It is necessary **to speak** English to work in a hotel.*

*It is wonderful **to have** close friends.*

When you describe something with an adjective (underlined in the examples above), an infinitive should follow (**in bold**). Using gerunds here would be incorrect.

But remember! If you want to make that object into a subject (see RULE 1), a gerund should be used:

Graduating from university is not easy.

Speaking English is necessary to work in a hotel.

Having close friends is wonderful.

How else do you know if an adjective should be followed by an infinitive? The construct "**too + [adjective]**" is another way to tell!

For example:

*This dress is too big **to wear**.*

*This car is too expensive **to buy**.*

And the same is true about "**[adjective] + enough**":

*My child is not tall enough **to ride** this rollercoaster.*

*The course was detailed enough **to widen** his knowledge base.*

*This rule is useful enough **to understand** the usage of infinitives!*

RULE 4: Only infinitives are used after certain verbs followed by nouns or pronouns referring to a person.

"We asked her not to go."

In this sentence, "we" is the subject, "asked" is the verb and "her" is the objective form of the pronoun "she." You must use an infinitive ("to go"), never a gerund, after certain verbs followed by nouns or pronouns referring to people.

To remember this rule, you will have to study verbs that take an object and an infinitive in this context.

Start with these examples. The objects (nouns and pronouns) are underlined. Notice how the underlined objects are all followed by infinitives.

ask: *Can I ask you **to help** me with something?*

expect: *I never expected him **to become** famous.*

hire (give a job to someone): *Did the company hire you just **to sit** in your office?*

invite: *I invited a friend **to attend** the ceremony.*

order: *She ordered the child **to stay** at home.*

remind: *Please remind me **to wash** the dishes.*

require: *The test required him **to concentrate** fully.*

teach: *That will teach you **to follow** the rules!*

tell: *Who told you **to come** here?*

urge: *They urged me **to continue** my research.*

warn: *I am warning you **not to do** this!*

RULE 5: Only gerunds are used after prepositions (with one exception).

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Consider this sentence:

I talked him out of taking that job.

Here, the gerund "taking" follows the preposition "of."

Prepositions can follow any word, be it a noun, a pronoun, a verb or an adjective. In the examples below, the prepositions are underlined, followed by the gerunds in bold.

A preposition that follows a noun:

*Novels about **growing up** are popular among teenagers.*

*I have an interest in **becoming** a painter.*

A preposition that follows a pronoun:

*I forgive you for **not telling** the truth.*

A preposition that follows a verb:

*She is thinking about **trying** martial arts.*

*He looks forward to **meeting** his cousins.*

A preposition that follows an adjective:

*I am wary of **going** alone.*

*My mom is scared of **flying**.*

There is one exception. Thankfully, it should be easy to remember!

THE EXCEPTION

"But" is a short word that connects two clauses of a sentence together. It is called a conjunction. Sometimes, "but" can also play a role of a preposition. When "but" is used as a preposition, it is the same in meaning as "except."

If "but" or "except" are used like this, they need to be followed by an infinitive:

*I had no choice but **to follow** her.*

(I had to follow her.)

*Mary made no stops on the way except **to get** gas.*

(Mary only stopped to get gas.)

*There is nothing left for me to do but **to collect** my money and go.*

(I only have to collect my money and go.)

You may not see "but" and "except" used this way often. Just follow the rule of gerunds after prepositions, and you will get it right most of the time!

Gerunds and infinitives may be confusing, but they make your English speech more varied and colorful. It is very useful to study them and practice using them correctly. The more you notice gerunds and infinitives in your study of the English language, the easier it will get!

Sometimes you will be unsure if you need to use an infinitive or a gerund in a sentence. In this situation, try changing the sentence and saying what you want to say in a different way.

GERUND OR INFINITIVE (...OR BOTH) Practice:

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Read "Ali's Story" below, and circle the correct answer for the words in **bold** [1 - 34].

Decide whether you need to use a gerund, infinitive or both forms of the word.

Ali's Story

Booking a School

Ali decided that he wanted [1] **to study / studying** abroad. In order [2] **to achieve / achieving** his goal, he had many things that he had [3] **to do / doing**. Firstly, he needed [4] **to improve / improving** his English so he could take the IELTS test. Unfortunately, Ali disliked [5] **to learn / learning** English so this would not be much fun. His friend recommended [6] **to attend / attending** a school close to his house. Ali went to look and from what he could see it seemed [7] **to be / being** a good school. He didn't delay [8] **to register / registering** for a course. He managed [9] **to get / getting** a good price for the course because they had a special offer on. This was good because he could not afford [10] **to pay / paying** too much.

Studying

He had never read much in his life and knew he was weak in this area, so he practiced [11] **to read / reading** as much as he could. He hated [12] **to write / writing** in English too as his grammar was quite weak, so he also planned [13] **to practice / practicing** writing as many essays as possible. His teachers agreed [14] **to check / checking** these for him. As it turned out, Ali actually really enjoyed [15] **to study / studying** English. The other students on the course didn't hesitate [16] **to help / helping** Ali and the teachers always offered [17] **to assist / assisting** him if he was stuck. He kept up his studying for a number of months because he wouldn't risk [18] **to sit / sitting** the exam until he was ready.

Taking the Test

Then came the time for Ali [19] **to take / taking** the test. He couldn't stop [20] **to worry / worrying** before the test. His teacher had recommended [21] **to do / doing** Task 2 first in the writing, so he followed those instructions. He finished [22] **to write / writing** his Task 2 after exactly 40 minutes and then went on to Task 1. The speaking test seemed [23] **to go / going** quite well even though he was nervous. He could recall [24] **to ask / asking** the examiner at the end how well he had done but she refused [25] **to tell /telling** him. Then came the time for his result. He had expected [26] **to get / getting** a band 5.5 but he was surprised [27] **to find / finding** out that he had been given a band 6.

The Result

So Ali could now go and study abroad. Although he was happy, unfortunately this meant [28] **to leave / leaving** his wife and children for a year. He considered [29] **to take / taking** them with him but it would be too expensive. He knew he would miss [30] **to see / seeing** them every day but his parents offered [31] **to take / taking** care of them and promised [32] **to make / making** sure they were safe. Ali did love [33] **to travel / traveling** though, so he knew he would enjoy the trip. He began [34] **to prepare / preparing** for his trip immediately.